LOAD SHEDDING

Written by

The Panelwise team

Self-written sample screenplay for Panelwise.
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FADE IN:

1 INT. HIGH SCHOOL - CLASSROOM 4B - EVENING 1

Rows of wooden desks scratched with initials. A chalkboard reads: FINAL MATHS EXAM - 18:00 TO 20:00. Rain against the windows.

MS. MOLEFE (40s), cardigan, red pen tucked behind one ear, walks between the desks laying exam papers face down.

Six learners wait. AYANDA (17), braids, chews her pencil. JABU (17), tall, knee bouncing under the desk. FATIMA (16), calculator lined up with her ruler.

PIETER (17), sleepy, hood up. NOMSA (16), praying with her eyes closed. And LUCKY (17), at the back, already sweating.

MS. MOLEFE
You may turn your papers over. You have two hours. Good luck.

Paper rustles. Pencils start scratching.

The lights flicker. Buzz. Then the room goes black.

2 INT. HIGH SCHOOL - CLASSROOM 4B - CONTINUOUS 2

Darkness. Rain. A few phone screens glow blue.

LUCKY
(whispering)
Load shedding. Thank you, Lord.

JABU
It's a sign. The exam is cancelled.

MS. MOLEFE (O.S.)
Nobody is cancelling anything. Phones face down on the desks.

A match flares. Ms. Molefe's face appears in the small flame. She lights a CANDLE in a saucer.

MS. MOLEFE
Every teacher in this country keeps candles in the bottom drawer. Fatima, help me.

FATIMA
How many are there, Miss?

MS. MOLEFE
Enough.

3 INT. HIGH SCHOOL - CLASSROOM 4B - MOMENTS LATER 3

Fatima and Ms. Molefe set a candle on every desk. The room fills with small trembling lights. Shadows of the learners stretch huge across the walls.

Pieter pulls his hood down and stares at his candle.

PIETER
This is actually quite nice.

AYANDA
Quiet, Pieter. Some of us are doing question two.

NOMSA
(opening her eyes)
I can't read the graph. It's too dark.

MS. MOLEFE
Bring your desk to the window. The streetlight is still on outside.

NOMSA
The streetlight works and the school doesn't?

MS. MOLEFE
Welcome to engineering. That's question seven.

The class laughs. Nomsa drags her desk to the window.

4 INT. HIGH SCHOOL - CLASSROOM 4B - LATER 4

The candles have burned down by half. Wax pools in the saucers.

Lucky stares at a blank page. He looks across at Jabu's paper. Jabu covers it with his arm without looking up.

Ms. Molefe crouches beside Lucky's desk.

MS. MOLEFE
(quietly)
Which one?

LUCKY
All of them, Miss.

CONTINUED:

MS. MOLEFE
Then start with the one you know a little. Not the one you know nothing about.

Lucky looks at his paper for a long moment. Then he picks up his pencil and begins to write.

5 INT. HIGH SCHOOL - CLASSROOM 4B - NIGHT 5

The wall clock reads eight o'clock. Ms. Molefe stands at the front.

MS. MOLEFE
Pencils down.

Six pencils go down. The candles are stubs now.

The lights buzz and flicker on. Everybody squints. Groans.

JABU
Now it comes back.

PIETER
I liked the candles better.

FATIMA
(handing in her paper)
Miss, can we write all our exams like this?

MS. MOLEFE
Ask the power station.

Ms. Molefe collects the last paper, from Lucky. There's writing on every page. She looks at him. He shrugs, half smiling.

She blows out the last candle.

FADE OUT.